14.33 Research and Communication in Economics

Fall 2026

Last updated: September 28, 2026

Course information

Class meetings	Mondays and Wednesdays, 10:30 a.m.–12:00 p.m.
Location	E51-395 (primary classroom); E51-385 (breakout space)
Instructor	Jon Cohen (jpcohen@mit.edu), E52-508 Office hours: Mondays, 2:00–4:00 p.m.
Teaching assistant	Laurel Britt (lrl@mit.edu) Office hours: Fridays, 10:00–11:00 a.m. E52-548 and 4:00–5:00 p.m. E52-416
Communication Center	Cameron Netland (camnet@mit.edu), E18-228 Office hours: by appointment
MIT Library	Nicholas Albaugh (nalbaugh@mit.edu), 14S-202 Office hours: by appointment

Course description

The course will guide students through the design, execution, and communication of an economics research project. It emphasizes research judgment, reproducible workflows, responsible use of AI, writing clarity, and the ability to explain one's work.

Learning objectives

By the end of the semester, students will be able to:

Course competency	Broader purpose
Formulate an original research question	Develop creativity and taste
Organize a version-controlled, one-click reproducible research pipeline	Practice structured automation
Use AI productively for research and coding	Treat AI as a complement rather than a substitute
Write a clear research paper	Use writing to clarify, test, and develop ideas
Communicate progress concisely in writing and in meetings	Learn to "manage up" effectively

Course competency	Broader purpose
Provide constructive feedback on peer projects	Build collaboration-based social skills
Present and defend the project's research design, analysis, code, and conclusions	Strengthen verbal communication

Course format

- 8 class meetings will be lectures. Each lecture will have a small but mandatory assignment to complete beforehand. The goal is to have the lectures be interactive, so thoughtfully engaging with the assigned material and completing the mandatory assignment prior to class is essential.
- 12 class meetings will be research meetings. Students will rotate between scheduled 1-on-1 meetings with the instructor or TA. At least 24 hours before each 1-on-1 meeting, the student will submit a meeting-specific GitHub issue (see bottom of syllabus for details). When the student is not in a 1-on-1 meeting, they will be in assigned small groups to do a project-related exercise or provide structured peer feedback.
- 2 class meetings will focus exclusively on small-group writing exercises.
- 4 class meetings will be presentations in front of your peers.
- The final exam will be a closed-book, individualized written exam assessing the student's understanding of their code and project. It will take place Tuesday, December 15, 2026, from 9:00 a.m. to 12:00 p.m. in E51-145.

Grading

Final grade calculation:

- 15% pre-class assignments and meeting-preparation issues
- 5% paper outline (due Monday October 19 by 10:30am)
- 5% initial paper draft (due Monday November 2 by 10:30am)
- 10% revised paper draft (due Wednesday November 18 by 10:30am)
- 20% final paper (due Friday December 4 by 11:59pm)
- 5% final code quality and reproducibility (due Friday December 4 by 11:59pm)
- 15% final presentation (December 7 or December 9)
- 25% final exam (Tuesday, December 15, 9:00 a.m.–12:00 p.m., E51-145)

Attendance

In-person attendance is mandatory. Feedback with the professor, the TA, and peers is a core component of the class. There will be a full final letter grade deduction for more than two unexcused absences. The Wednesday class before Thanksgiving will meet but will not count as an unexcused absence if missed.

Students are encouraged to reach out to the professor and TA at least a week in advance if there is a known scheduling conflict, such as for religious observance. Any absence that was not requested

with supporting information more than 48 hours in advance of the class can be marked as excused only with written confirmation from MIT Student Support Services (S3).

Laptop and cell phone use

No cell phone use is allowed during any class meeting for any reason, while laptops are permitted for only limited use. Laptops are permitted for individual meetings with the instructor or TA for reviewing the GitHub issue at hand but not allowed during lectures. During peer feedback group meetings, the student sharing results or soliciting feedback is allowed to use a laptop but the others are not. The rationale is that randomized controlled trials at universities demonstrate the learning benefits of prohibiting laptop and cell phone use.

Artificial intelligence use

AI is a part of the modern research process and thus within the course's subject matter. The course's structure and AI policy are intended to encourage student behavior that facilitates learning. Students are expected to use tools in ways that support their reasoning abilities rather than replace them. Students must understand and be accountable for all of their work.

Because the iterative process of revising writing is a necessary foundational skill, AI usage is explicitly forbidden for one component of the class: writing prose in papers. All prose–the written text that appears as words in paper drafts–must be manually drafted and edited by students. Therefore, students must manually use Google Docs while connected to the internet when drafting prose.

Students are expected to comply with this policy in the spirit of mutual respect, but the instructor and TA will ensure compliance using several verification steps. Specifically, the instructor and TA will audit the edit history to ensure it was done manually and reserve the right to use AI writing detection software. Any suspected violations will be reported to MIT's Office of Student Conduct and Community Standards.

Assignment requirements

Bring a completed physical copy of each pre-class assignment to class. This may be handwritten or printed from a typed copy before class. This avoids needing a laptop for in-class exercises based on the assignment.

Every submitted assignment must include an AI-use statement. If there was no AI use, simply state that. If AI was forbidden for any component of the assignment, attest that you complied with that restriction. If there was any AI use, write 2–4 sentences describing what you used it for, one benefit, and one limitation. You may consider two dimensions:

- *Your assignment*: Did AI improve the result or expand what you could do? Did its output require verification, create errors, or steer you toward an unproductive approach?
- *Your learning*: Did AI reveal something you did not know or help you understand the material? Did it replace practice needed to develop a skill?

Required text and materials

- Varanya Chaubey, *The Little Book of Research Writing*.
- Three months of a $20-per-month subscription to an approved frontier LLM (e.g., Claude, ChatGPT, or Gemini) for use with exclusively low-risk, non-Institute data. If you are using at least medium-risk Institute data, then you must use an MIT Parley account. Parley has a browser chat and a separate, usage-priced API that can also connect to coding agents. Refer to MIT's Generative AI usage policy guidance for more detail.
- Paper notebook and pen/pencil brought to each class meeting.
- Free GitHub account and Google account. Students will add the instructor and TA as collaborators to their project's GitHub repository and as editors to all Google Docs.

Accessibility and accommodations

MIT is committed to the principle of equal access. Students who need disability accommodations are encouraged to speak with Disability and Access Services (DAS), prior to or early in the semester so that accommodation requests can be evaluated and addressed in a timely fashion. The instructor and TA are ready to assist with any approved accommodations.

Late submissions

The course structure scaffolds assignments to build on one another, so it is highly encouraged to submit all assignments on time. Late submission grades are penalized 25 points (out of 100 total potential points) per delayed day to incentivize timely submissions. The only exception is for a documented accommodation from MIT S3.

Inclusion

Course participants will refer to one another using each person's preferred first name. Using preferred first names rather than pronouns has two purposes: engender a collegial atmosphere and avoid unintentional misgendering. Students will be provided name cards to facilitate learning each other's names. The one exception is for communicating with the instructor: please address the instructor and all other faculty members as 'Professor [Last Name]' in speech and email, unless expressly invited to do otherwise. The purpose is to maintain professional equity and respect for all instructors.

Students are expected to be respectful when providing peer feedback. A growth mindset is useful when receiving feedback, but this is difficult to do when the feedback is ad hominem or destructive rather than substantive and constructive. Students should report any concerns to either the instructor or TA.

Course Feedback

The course is structured to facilitate learning, but the instructor and TA are open to your feedback on how it can be improved. There will be a formal process at the course midpoint for collecting and addressing feedback on what's going well and what's not going well. But students are encouraged to anonymously send in constructive feedback to this form at any point in the semester.

Tentative class schedule

No.	Date	Class content	Assignment(s) due
1	Wed., Sept. 9	Lecture: Course Overview	N/A
2	Mon., Sept. 14	Lecture: Developing a Research Topic	>=5 of each: potential questions, potential settings, and potential data sources
3	Wed., Sept. 16	Individual meetings	• Meeting-preparation issue • Preliminary ranking of 5 potential question + setting + data combinations
4	Mon., Sept. 21	Individual meetings	Meeting-preparation issue
5	Wed., Sept. 23	Lecture: Version Control and Reproducibility	Git exercises
6	Mon., Sept. 28	Lecture: Effective AI usage	Watch Paul Goldsmith-Pinkham's NBER lecture on AI usage. Write >=3 questions or points of confusion you have about the content.
7	Wed., Sept. 30	Lecture: Scripted Data Collection and Exploration	• Feasibility writeup of >=1 data source of each type: downloadable tabular, web scraped, free text, optical character recognition (OCR), Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) request • Review MIT librarian's slide deck and complete short form 24 hours in advance of class
8	Mon., Oct. 5	Lightning topic presentations	1 slide project proposal overview
9	Wed., Oct. 7	Individual meetings	• Meeting-preparation issue • 1-paragraph project proposal
—	Mon., Oct. 12	**No class — Indigenous Peoples' Day**	N/A
10	Tues., Oct. 13	Lecture: Structure of a Research Paper	Read through "Layer 1" of Chaubey (pages 1-59) and write a >=1 sentence takeaway of each section
11	Wed., Oct. 14	Small group exercises on paper outline	Read through "Layer 2" of Chaubey (pg 59-85) and write a >=1 sentence takeaway of each section
12	Mon., Oct. 19	Individual meetings	• Meeting-preparation issue • Paper outline
13	Wed., Oct. 21	Individual meetings	• Meeting-preparation issue • Mid-course feedback

No.	Date	Class content	Assignment(s) due
14	Mon., Oct. 26	Small group exercises on paper drafting	Complete Chaubey (pg 99-173) and write a >=1 sentence takeaway of each section
15	Wed., Oct. 28	Individual meetings	Meeting-preparation issue
16	Mon., Nov. 2	Individual meetings	• Meeting-preparation issue • Paper draft
17	Wed., Nov. 4	Individual meetings	• Meeting-preparation issue • Feedback provided on paper drafts
18	Mon., Nov. 9	Individual meetings	Meeting-preparation issue
—	Wed., Nov. 11	**No class — Veterans Day**	N/A
19	Mon., Nov. 16	Lecture: Combining Theory and Empirics	>=1 sentence each on: >=3 general economic principles that the paper's results demonstrate/test and >=3 mechanisms that could drive the paper's results
20	Wed., Nov. 18	Individual meetings	• Meeting-preparation issue • Revised paper draft
21	Mon., Nov. 23	Individual meetings	Meeting-preparation issue
22	Wed., Nov. 25	Individual meetings (excused absence for Thanksgiving travel)	Meeting-preparation issue
23	Mon., Nov. 30	Lecture: Giving an effective talk	Draft titles for each slide
24	Wed., Dec. 2	Small group practice presentations	• Draft presentation • Final paper due Fri., Dec 4
25	Mon., Dec. 7	Final presentations	N/A
26	Wed., Dec. 9	Final presentations	N/A
27	Tues., Dec. 15	Written final exam (9:00 a.m.–12:00 p.m., E51-145)	N/A

Individual meeting preparation

This section details how students will prepare agendas for their 1-on-1 meetings. At least 24 hours before the meeting, the student will open a meeting-specific issue in their GitHub repository using the template below. The instructor or TA will prepare for the meeting by reading the meeting agenda issue beforehand. The suggested word count for the agenda is approximately 250 words, excluding links and tables. Students should focus on results and decisions rather than time spent (e.g., write "Estimated the baseline specification and found…" rather than "Worked on regressions").

Students will use the following labels for both the overall project and the next course deliverable:

- **On track:** Progress can continue without intervention.
- **At risk:** A problem could affect the project or deliverable, but there is a plausible path forward.
- **Blocked:** Progress requires a decision or assistance that is not independently obtainable.

Students are required to link to evidence in their GitHub repository within the meeting agenda. They are highly encouraged to use separate GitHub issues for tracking consequential unresolved decisions or incomplete tasks. When collecting evidence on major decisions, they are also highly encouraged to test alternatives on short-lived branches.

For concreteness, suppose an unresolved decision is about the main sample composition. The student would create a separate issue titled "Choose the appropriate sample definition," which would be automatically numbered by GitHub (e.g., #23). The student could test alternatives on branches named `23-full-sample` and `23-restricted-sample` and summarize the key differences in a comparison table in issue #23. The meeting agenda would link to issue #23 as an unresolved decision. Once a decision is made, the student would record the rationale in issue #23, merge the chosen branch into the main branch, and close issue #23.

After the meeting, students will update the agenda with next steps and record any resolved decisions in the linked decision issues.

1-on-1 meeting agenda issue template

Title the issue `Meeting preparation — YYYY-MM-DD`.

1. Bottom line

- **Overall project:** On track / At risk / Blocked (one-sentence explanation)
- **Next course deliverable:** Name and due date
- **Deliverable status:** On track / At risk / Blocked (one-sentence explanation)
- **Goal for this meeting:** By the end of the meeting, I want to have decided or resolved…

2. Current project state

Work modes: Not started / Building / Testing / Revising / Rebuilding / Holding steady

For each row, select the progress description that best represents what is currently usable and the work mode that best represents your current focus.

2a. Research components

Component	Current progress	Primary work mode
Research question	None / Candidate questions / Working question	Select one work mode
Data	None / Candidate sources / Raw data / Analysis dataset / Documented quality checks	Select one work mode
Analysis	None / Analysis ideas / Documented descriptives / Baseline estimate / Reproducible baseline	Select one work mode

2b. Paper writing

Writing artifacts: None / Notes or outline / Partial draft / Complete working draft

Paper section	Current usable artifact	Primary work mode
Data	Select one writing artifact	Select one work mode
Methodology	Select one writing artifact	Select one work mode
Results	Select one writing artifact	Select one work mode
Introduction	Select one writing artifact	Select one work mode

3. Progress and learnings

Report concrete findings rather than activities or time spent. Findings can be unexpected results or newly-discovered roadblocks.

- **Finding:** Brief description + link to evidence
- **Finding:** Brief description + link to evidence

Implication: How did this help you make progress on the project? How does it inform the project's next steps?

4. Decisions, questions, or blockers

Include 1-3 items, ordered by descending importance. For a blocker, include what you have already tried and the specific help needed in the brief description.

1. **Decision, question, or blocker:** Brief description
   - **Context and evidence:** Link to a separate issue, or provide 1–2 sentences explaining the relevant context and evidence.
   - **Preliminary recommendation and reasoning (pre-meeting):** Completed prior to the meeting with the perceived best path forward
   - **Next steps (post-meeting):** Completed after the meeting before resolving the meeting agenda, potentially linking to newly-created GitHub issues
2. …
3. …

5. Committed next steps

Draft this section prior to the meeting and revise this section after the meeting. List 1-3 commitments. Each commitment should identify an observable output, its target date, and what will count as complete.

1. **Specific deliverable (target date):** One-sentence completion criterion + optional link to GitHub issue
2. …
3. …

Revision history

- **September 28, 2026:** Added final exam details and clarified Parley web chat and API access.

- **September 14, 2026:** Replaced office hours availability poll with scheduled times.
- **September 9, 2026:** Added excused attendance procedures and AI disclosure policy.